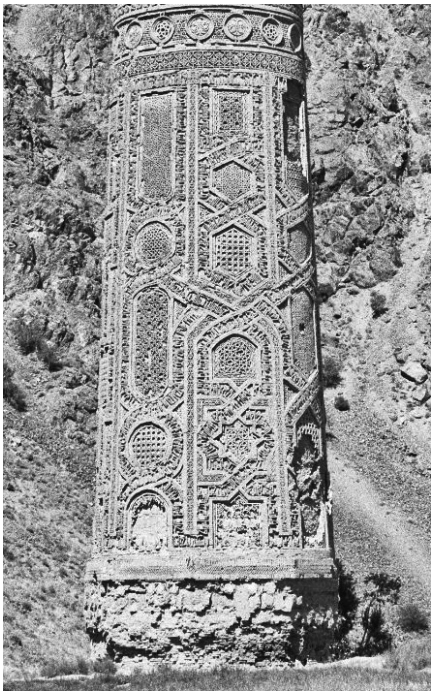


Figure 3.6 *Detail of Figure 3.4: Jam, minaret, view of* mihrab *relief on east face.*

ornamentation, a towering pointed-arch blind niche distinguishes the eastern face of the *minar* from the other surfaces. In fact, the most important verses of Surat Maryam (Q. XIX: 35–41) were ingeniously placed at the apex of this niche motif, which, together with its *qibla* orientation, strongly points to its function as a *mihrab*.[31]

Sourdel-Thomine cautioned against considering the *minar*'s ornamented niche as "a secondary *mihrab*, but rather [as] adding an *Islamic* element to the symbolic, religious and sacred quality of a monument with marked cardinal orientations" (i.e., *via* the decorative programs of each of the eight faces).[32] Nevertheless, a *mihrab* on the *minar* would have been redundant *vis-à-vis* an adjacent mosque's *qibla* wall, and too close to the latter to allow for separate worship. Given the labor and resources invested in the *minar* – including the difficult spatial calculations required to integrate the *mihrab* motif and its meaningful verses seamlessly within the complex decorative program – it is safe to assume that one of the principal aims of the overall œuvre was to be visible, if not also *legible* (cf. Chapter 4). Thus, at the time of the *minar*'s construction, it is possible that an unroofed prayer area or *'idgah* might have already been in place, even marking the *qibla* by means of a low wall permitting visibility beyond.[33] The eventual construction of the *minar* in AH 570/1174–1175 CE obviously served multiple purposes, as discussed in the next chapter; a significant